

Lesson 9: Pat Sings Rocky Top

Jimmy Delaney

When Pat was coaching, it was mid to late 2000s, and the men's basketball coach that was here, you know, kind of did some crazy antics and all of that, and painted his chest and came to a game. And national news and great support and the fans loved it and all of that.

And so, Pat was sitting there and she was like, well, I need to do something for a men's basketball game. And what is it that I can do? And I wanted to be kind of something wild and fun and crazy. And so we were sitting around the table, Dean Lockwood and Holly and Nikki and a few of us were all just trying to throw out ideas and this and that.

And what a lot of folks may or may not realize, Pat, you know, she never said she had the greatest singing voice, but she loved Rocky Top and she loved singing Rocky Top. And so whether, you know, she was having a dinner at her house or, you know, speaking engagement, whatever it was, at some point she kind of would work in breaking into Rocky Top.

And so we're like, Pat, what if you go out and you sing Rocky Top? And she's like, well, I can do that, but is that enough? Like he painted his chest. And so we started talking more and we're like, well, what if we kind of did it under the slight of hand and, you know, we have all the cheerleaders kind of crowd around you and you just hear this voice. And it might take people a second to recognize the voice or whatever it is, but you're kind of singing and all of that.

And then we're like, what if you guys dressed up as cheerleaders? And there was about 30 seconds of silence in the room. And I was like, okay, so that's the bad idea and I'm never going to be invited to a brainstorm again. And she looked at me and she goes, you can get us cheerleader uniforms that'll fit all of us? And I was like, sure we can.

And she was like, all right, so I run off, get with the cheer coach, get the uniforms, bring them back in, lay them on the table a day or two later. And everyone comes in and Pat's like, all right, we're doing this. And there was about five to 10 minutes of laughter because I think at that point in their career and their life, they had never imagined that they'd be wearing a cheerleading uniform. Dean Lockwood probably was my favorite because the minute he put on the top and the pants, he immediately started going into the arm pumping and all of that.

But we got the entire coaching staff, Pat included, dressed up in cheerleading outfits and nobody knew about it. Got them down into the tunnel at the men's game. Peyton Manning happened to be at that game, which was kind of even more incredible. Dick Vitale was calling the game for TV. And so everything was lining up, a sold-out game and all of that.

And so we go and grab the microphone. We had scripted in the timeout. We didn't tell anybody other than the cheerleaders that were surrounding them like, hey, the start of this timeout, it's just going to be a bit where the cheerleaders come out. And we're standing back there.

And I remember Pat said, she goes, "How do I look?" And I said, "Ridiculous, but you go on in 30 seconds." And so, she grabbed the mic and she said, "Is this thing on?" I said, "Oh, it's on." And so the timeout happens, and the cheerleaders crowd around her, and she starts into the "Wish that I was..." and the place immediately goes nuts. And I don't know that I've heard Thompson Bowling Arena louder. And then they make a pyramid, and they put Pat at the top. And that was one of like the lasting images I have.